

Custom Site vs. Squarespace

A quick breakdown for Drew & Max | March 2026 | Prepared by Andrew

Where Things Stand

Your site is 29 static pages with images and a workaround booking flow (\$0 products added to a Squarespace cart). You don't use any Squarespace-only features. Your two external services—**Acuity Scheduling** and **Square Payments**—work on any platform. They're not tied to Squarespace and wouldn't change at all.

Moving to a custom site hosted on Vercel or Cloudflare Pages would cost **~\$10/year** (just the domain) vs. **\$300–700/year** on Squarespace. But the real argument isn't cost—it's **speed, flexibility, and protection**.

Speed: Why Changes Get Faster

I use an AI-powered coding tool (Claude Code) that can build, edit, and maintain websites extremely fast—but **it can't touch Squarespace**. Squarespace is a closed platform. Every change you request on Squarespace costs me 3–5× the time it would on a custom site.

Task	On Squarespace	On Custom Site
Change colors/fonts site-wide	Click through every section	One command, done in seconds
Add a new studio set page	Copy page, edit every block	Duplicate template, auto-fill
Redesign the gallery	Limited to SQ gallery blocks	Any layout, full control
Add features (chat, automations)	Not possible	Built & deployed same day
Fix something on all 29 pages	Edit each page one by one	One command updates all

ADA Compliance: Custom Is Safer

You may have heard about serial ADA lawsuits—lawyers scan websites with automated tools and sue small businesses over accessibility failures (missing image descriptions, poor contrast, keyboard issues). **Over 4,000 federal cases were filed in 2024 alone**, and small businesses are the primary target.

The **risk of getting sued is the same** on either platform—serial plaintiffs scan the output, not the tech stack. But your ability to **fix issues** is dramatically better on a custom site:

	Squarespace	Custom Site
Baseline accessibility	Some built-in support	WCAG 2.1 AA from day one
Control over fixes	Can't modify SQ's code	Full control over everything
Third-party code	SQ injects code you can't audit	You choose what's on the page
Ongoing compliance	Manual checks, no tooling	Claude Code audits & fixes all pages in one pass

On Squarespace, some accessibility problems are **baked into the platform** and you literally cannot fix them.

Your External Services Stay Put

- **Acuity Scheduling** — Works standalone. One embed line on the new site. Same links, same flow.
- **Square Payments** — Processed externally. Works anywhere. No change needed.

Nothing breaks. Nothing migrates. They just keep working.

Cost Comparison

	Squarespace (current)	Custom Site
Hosting	\$276–468/yr	\$0
Domain	~\$20/yr	~\$10/yr
Acuity (if keeping)	\$240/yr	\$240/yr
Annual total	\$536–728	\$250
5-year total	\$2,680–3,640	\$1,250

If you switch from Acuity to a free alternative (Cal.com), the custom site drops to **~\$10/year**.

The One Tradeoff

You'd lose **Squarespace's visual drag-and-drop editor**. If you need a text or image change:

1. Text me—I push the change in under 5 minutes (Claude Code makes this trivial).
2. Or we set up a free browser-based CMS so you can edit content yourselves.

If you rarely edit the site yourselves (which seems to be the case), this doesn't matter.

Timeline

We already have a 4-page mockup built with the design system, fonts, and logo. Remaining work: **~16–24 hours** to finish all pages, set up hosting, migrate images, and go live. Realistically **1–2 weeks** of part-time sessions.

Bottom Line: You're paying \$300–700/yr for a platform that slows down every change, can't be automated, limits your features, and gives you less control over ADA compliance. The migration is straightforward and your external services don't change.